Rapheal Prince Obodugo

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PROFILE

Engineer and founder with a decade of experience across fintech infrastructure, AI product development, and open source software. Built and exited a bootstrapped West African fintech serving 360,000 users. Admitted to Toptal — the global network for the top 3% of engineers. Currently building Avae AI.

RECOGNITION & VALIDATION

Toptal Verified Expert	Admitted May 2021 — fewer than 3% of applicants accepted globally
NVIDIA Inception Programme	Avae AI accepted, February 2026
Google for Startups Cloud Programme	Avae AI accepted, January 2026
MARL Studio Accelerator	Spring 2026 Cohort #13, February 2026
Unicorn Factory Lisboa	Summer Batch 2025 — EU market expansion and investor readiness

MEDIA & PUBLIC RECOGNITION

- **CNBC Africa Power Lunch West Africa** (March 2026, live studio broadcast, 10K+ views) — Selected as AI Expert alongside the Dean of Lagos Business School and CEO of SeamlessHR for a panel on AI and the future of skills in Africa
- **Business Insider Africa** (March 2026) — Featured on bootstrapping a fintech to 360,000 users and $6.7K MRR without external funding
- **The Nation Nigeria** (October 2025) — Independent profile documenting a decade-long engineering career across Nigeria, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, and Europe
- **DevFest Enugu 2025** (December 2025, 1,300+ attendees, 9.1K views) — Panelist, The Future of Work: The 9-to-5 and the Gig Economy in the Age of AI, Google Developer Groups

OPEN SOURCE CONTRIBUTIONS

- **ip-address** (172M downloads/month) — PR #180: added `Address4.fromByteArray()` for API consistency with `Address6`; merged November 2025
- **express-slow-down** (315K downloads/month) — PR #69: integration test for timer cleanup on connection close events, eliminating memory leaks on premature disconnection; merged November 2025
- **express-useragent** (99K weekly downloads, 309 dependents) — PR #179: fixed `isBot` to always return boolean, resolving TikTok WebView false positives across five open issues; merged November 2025

EXPERIENCE

Founder · Avae AI · Dec 2025 – Present · Lagos, Nigeria
Building an AI-powered continuous audit platform for modern finance.

Web Engineering Lead · Derayah Financial · Jan 2025 – Jan 2026 · Saudi Arabia
Led product engineering for a high-volume retail trading platform under live market and regulatory constraints. Re-architected core investing dashboards for correctness, latency, and state consistency under real-time data feeds. Built and led the web engineering team from role definition and hiring through to execution standards and delivery cadence.

Co-Founder & CEO (Acquired) · MySub · Jan 2023 – Dec 2025 · US / West Africa
Founded a shared-payment infrastructure platform for West Africa — pooling money for rent, subscriptions, school fees, and travel. Bootstrapped to 360,000 users and $6.7K MRR without external funding; exited via strategic acquisition reported in Punch Nigeria and Business Insider Africa. Growth driven entirely through community embedding — no paid marketing.

Applied AI & Quantitative Systems · Independent Reserve · 2024 – 2025 · New York (Remote)
Built probabilistic models and simulation frameworks for short-term FX volatility in peer-to-peer currency markets. Developed execution logic to translate model outputs into actionable decisions under uncertainty.

Founding Engineer · HitPay (YC S21) · 2023 – 2024 · Singapore
Founding frontend engineer at a Southeast Asian payments infrastructure company. Designed the design system adopted across the entire frontend engineering team. Worked on reliability and open-banking integration patterns in a payments environment where bugs constitute financial incidents.

Senior Frontend Engineer · Landscape VC · 2023 · London, UK
Sole engineer responsible for rebuilding the v2 platform of an AI-powered private market intelligence tool for VC firms — startup discovery feeds, signal dashboards, and investor workflow tooling.

Senior Fullstack Engineer · Rollee · 2021 – 2022 · Paris, France (Remote)
Built core features for an open-finance platform providing financial institutions with verified income and employment data via API. Developed integrations with EU gig economy platforms for real-time payroll retrieval; spearheaded API reliability upgrades for lender clients.

Senior Software Engineer · Ecosia · Oct 2021 – Oct 2022 · Berlin, Germany
Architected and launched Ecosia's shopping vertical from inception to production.

Senior Frontend & UX Engineer · Baobab Partners · May 2019 – Jan 2022 · New York (Remote)
Led frontend development across a 2+ year engagement building enterprise-grade interfaces for finance and consultancy clients.

Software Engineer · PrepClassNG · Oct 2018 – Oct 2019 · Lagos, Nigeria
Fullstack engineer at a Lagos-based edtech startup.

SKILLS

Languages & Frameworks — JavaScript (14 yrs), TypeScript, Go, Python, Vue.js (10 yrs), React.js, Flutter, Laravel, Swift
Infrastructure — Google Cloud, Firebase, Supabase, Airtable, FlutterFlow
Domain — Fintech Infrastructure · Open Banking · AI Product Development · Quantitative Modelling · EU / US / Nigerian Regulatory Compliance